launched a series of terror strikes in the Jammu region, including the killing in Reasi of nine pilgrims travelling by bus. Another strike followed Omar Abdullah's swearing in as chief minister in October, when six migrants and a doctor were targeted in Ganderbal. Experts say security agencies should have been alert, particularly in a popular tourist location like Pahalgam, and beefed up presence in these areas. Ground forces in the Valley, therefore, need to analyse both the failure in intelligence as well as in what army calls 'area dominance' to prevent future attacks by Pakistan as India ups the ante. Lt Gen. Vinod Bhatia, former director general of military operations, stresses the need for an immediate and focused counterstrike. "The security forces must first hunt out the four militants who carried out the attack and eliminate them," he says. "Time, surprise and space are the key elements in the military domain. Action has to be pre-emptive, pro-active and punitive. And a punitive strategy must be at a time and place of our choosing."

EXPERTS SAY WE MUST RESIST JINGOISTIC DEMANDS TO 'TAKE BACK POK' AS IT MAY LEAD TO A PROLONGED WAR, LIKE RUSSIA IS FACING IN UKRAINE

THE OPTIONS BEFORE INDIA

According to a key military strategist, India should consider launching a multi-pronged offensive against Pakistan, one that spans the diplomatic, economic, military, political and informational domains. Given that the two countries had already expelled their respective high commissioners after the abrogation of Article 370, the current punitive action of reducing the staff strength of their missions is minimal. Two-way trade between the two countries is also a mere trickle, so there is not much India can do by way of economic sanctions.

What India can do is to rally major powers to penalise Pakistan for backing terror groups, using global watchdog FATF (Financial Action Task Force) which monitors terror financing. That, in turn, can restrict Pakistan's access to international financial institutions such as the IMF. Sabharwal also advocates for covert options targeting high-value figures in Pakistan, including top leaders of the JeM and the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) while ensuring deniability. After all, it is The Resistance Front (TRF), a proxy for the LeT, and the Peoples Anti-Fascist Front (PAFF), a front organisation of the JeM, that have claimed responsibility for the Pahalgam carnage. Pakistan's vulnerability to internal militants was evident when in 2009, local terror groups stormed the highly fortified General Headquarters of the army in Rawalpindi. They held armed forces personnel hostage for a while and killed a brigadier and a lieutenant, before the army killed the militants and regained control.

India has a broad range of options when it comes to overt punitive military action. According to Lt Gen. K.J.S. Dhillon, former GOC 15 Corps, Srinagar, "The military has prepared area-specific and depth-specific options, ranging from shallow to deep strikes, involving single or tri-service operations. These are pre-planned, rehearsed, and ready for execution upon approval. The response will be strategic, timed and aimed at delivering a disproportionate, crushing retaliation to inflict significant pain on Pakistan." Lt Gen. Deependra Singh Hooda, who led the 2016 surgical strikes in Uri as Northern Army commander, believes India can consider abandoning the existing LoC ceasefire agreement to begin with and launch surgical strikes on select targets. It could also deploy air force assets as it did in Balakot to hit terror infrastructure. According to the latest Indian intelligence reports, there are 42 active terrorist launch-pads in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) near the LoC, with 110-130 terrorists, including Pakistan nationals. Some strategists advocate a 'Balakot Plus' option, which would involve the use of India's short-range tactical ballistic missiles such as the Prithvi series and Pralay, the hypersonic Shaurya missile and the BrahMos cruise missile. All these systems are designed for battlefield use and can effectively strike strategic targets near the border. Hooda, though, cautions against the use of missiles given that Pakistan has a range of tactical missiles, both conventional and nuclear, and the situation could very rapidly escalate into a full-scale war.

Experts also warn against yielding to jingoistic demands by the political class to take back PoK. Military experts who have gamed the option say while India can capture a few features close to the LoC, seizing all of PoK could well be a three-year war as Russia is discovering with Ukraine. According to Hooda, "It would be a long-term campaign, with the Pakistani deployment matching the Indian one on the LoC." The problem may not end there either, he says. "Once you occupy it, it's not as though the people living there would welcome India. You could end up with other problems, including insurgency."

Pakistan also remains a nuclear-armed state that has shunned the 'no first-use' doctrine. It would not hesitate to exercise the option if its territorial integrity is under threat. The risk of a nuclear war, therefore, remains high. As such, India's response must be calibrated, encompassing strategic restraint and precision. In another significant turning point, much of the Valley showed no support for Pakistan's attack on the innocent tourists in Pahalgam. Political parties across the spectrum universally condemned the act; many joined public protests to express their outrage. With the public and political sentiment in its favour, India must exercise even greater circumspection so that it can deliver a befitting reply to Pakistan while retaining the moral high ground. ■

***–with* PRADIP R. SAGAR**